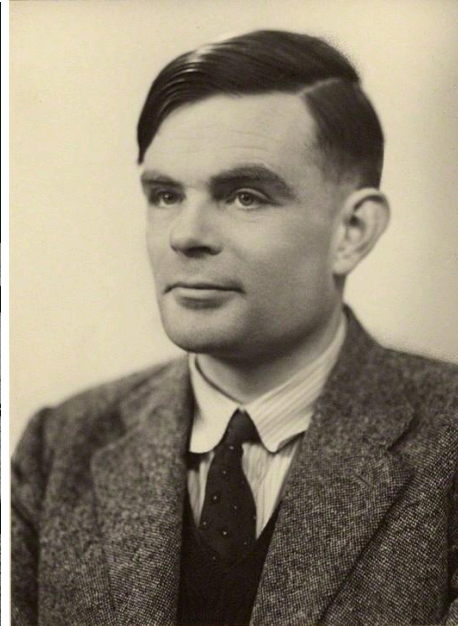
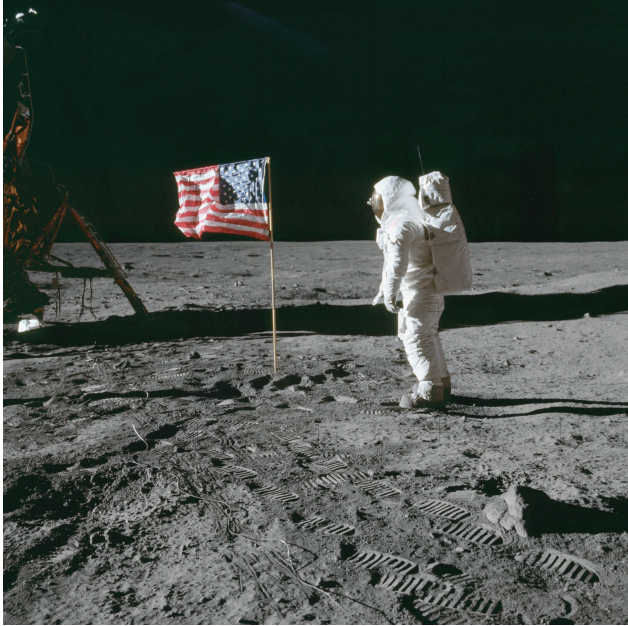
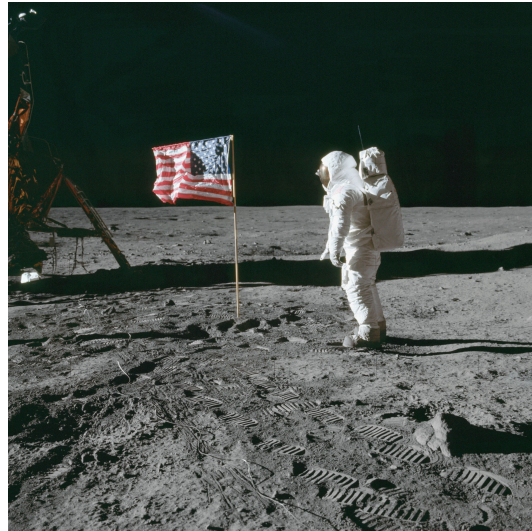


34 - In what ways do our values affect our acquisition of knowledge?





Edwin Aldrin with the American flag on the Moon

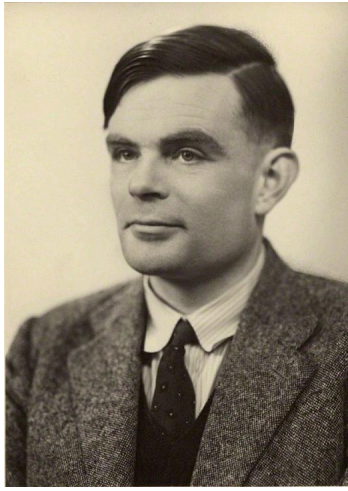
Image source: <https://www.nasa.gov/image-article/explorers-on-the-moon-apollo-11-landing/>

This is an image taken on 20th July, 1969 of Edwin “Buzz” Aldrin, who was part of the Apollo 11 mission and was one of the first men to step on the Moon (Luabeya). I have chosen to include this in my exhibition as it suggests that values such as patriotism can strongly drive the rapid acquisition of knowledge.

The Space Race was a fierce competition between the USA and USSR, originating from an arms race in rocket technology that was intended to deliver nuclear payloads (Manning). More knowledge about space flight and rocket propulsion was acquired through the use of weapons testing and subsequent test flights to space (Spadoni). The values of patriotism the American astronauts possessed drove them to rapidly acquire knowledge that would help their country preserve its ideology from communist expansion, by possessing more advanced weapons and technology to deter USSR expansion (Getchell). Today, the knowledge has been utilised by humanity for further acquisition of space knowledge.

Knowledge about artificial satellites was obtained during the race between the USA and USSR to achieve technological superiority in space, with both countries seeking to be the “firsts” to accomplish a feat, such as when the USSR launched the first successful artificial satellite into space (National Air And Space Museum). The values of pride for one’s country that the astronauts of the USA and USSR held contributed to the rush to acquire more scientific knowledge in order to show progress in the Space Race and improve public support. Such knowledge has benefited humanity, as multiple artificial satellites orbit the Earth today, granting us technology such as the Global Positioning System.

The Space Race directly led to the acquisition of knowledge related to science and space travel from the fierce competition between the USA and USSR, created by the patriotic values that the astronauts from each country held. This allowed humanity to acquire technological knowledge, resulting in availability of navigational systems that is widely utilised today.



Alan Turing

Image source: <https://www.iwm.org.uk/history/how-alan-turing-cracked-the-enigma-code>

This is Alan Turing, a British mathematician and computer scientist who laid the foundations of modern computing (Copeland). I have included this object because it shows how the impact of values such as love and loyalty can affect one's acquisition of knowledge.

In 1945, Turing acquired the knowledge of the modern computer's fundamental concepts with his creation of the first ever all-purpose computer with electronically stored data (Copeland). The value that drove this acquisition of knowledge was love. In his earlier years, Turing lost a friend that he had fallen in love with, Christopher Morcom (Highfield). Turing was deeply affected by Morcom's passing, and wished to "build a brain," (Chouard) which may have been an attempt at recreating the person he lost. The value of love for Morcom that Turing possessed pushed him to tackle problems related to the human mind, resulting in the acquisition of knowledge related to computing.

During World War Two, Turing acquired the knowledge of how to decipher Nazi Germany's Naval communications (Copeland) through his value of loyalty to Morcom. Following Morcom's death, Turing wished to honour his first love by being the first person in his school to win the prize that was named in memory of Christopher Morcom (The Fitzwilliam Museum). The mathematics book Turing chose as his award for obtaining the Christopher Morcom prize contained a chapter on codebreaking (The Fitzwilliam Museum). Turing's decision to go above and beyond in school to be the first in obtaining the prize that honoured his friend, allowed him to acquire his foundational knowledge of codebreaking, and likely ignited his journey towards saving lives through cracking the enigma code in World War Two (The Fitzwilliam Museum; Copeland).

Turing acquired knowledge related to the foundations of modern computing and saved lives through his acquisition of codebreaking knowledge due to his values of love for and loyalty to Morcom. As a result, humanity is able to benefit by acquiring more knowledge through modern computers while multiple lives were saved during World War Two.



Participants of the Tuskegee syphilis experiment

Image source: <https://www.history.com/news/the-infamous-40-year-tuskegee-study>

This image shows participants of the 1932 Tuskegee Syphilis Study, a medical experiment in Macon County, Alabama. According to research (Nix), the study aimed to investigate the full progression of the then-untreatable syphilis disease. I have chosen to include this as it critiques how unethical values such as racism can influence knowledge seekers to acquire knowledge through inhumane and barbaric ways.

Researchers acquired knowledge about how deadly the syphilis disease was, with more than a hundred participants dying from the disease within 40 years from the start of the study. (Nix). The knowledge was acquired through the value of determination that the study researchers possessed which outweighed their ethical obligations to treat study participants in humane ways. Although the medical knowledge acquired may have benefited humanity, the method in which said knowledge was acquired was unethical and barbaric, as men were intentionally left to die so that they could be studied.

The study also acquired the knowledge of symptoms associated with the syphilis disease in African American men. This was obtained through the racist and discriminatory values which the study's researchers held. According to a source (Brandt), multiple study organisers were shown to discriminate against African Americans, classifying them as different, lower beings from Caucasians. Such dehumanising comments created a scenario where the intentional deprivation of medical treatment for the study participants for the acquisition of knowledge was accepted by researchers of the study. While humanity holds the knowledge that untreated syphilis can cause blindness and insanity, the acquisition of it from this study was a moral and ethical failure of the public health system in America as a life-saving entity.

The Tuskegee Syphilis Study helped humanity acquire medical knowledge related to the syphilis disease. However, it was executed in an inhumane and immoral fashion, leaving more than a hundred people dead or seriously injured.

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